

Section A: Establishing the Context

In today's academic environment, most students are constantly using digital tools—whether it's making presentations, collaborating on Google Docs, or building profiles on platforms like LinkedIn and GitHub. At first glance, this makes it seem like our generation is highly “digitally skilled.” However, this case study highlights an important issue: there is a difference between *using* digital tools and actually *understanding* the digital systems behind them.

The main situation described in the case is about students like Arjun, who appear confident and active in digital spaces but lack deeper awareness. He creates online profiles, participates in group work, communicates through digital platforms, and even applies for opportunities online. Yet, in each of these situations, his actions reveal gaps in understanding—whether it is misrepresenting skills, relying on others in collaboration, using an inappropriate communication style, or falling for a phishing scam.

This situation matters because it reflects a broader reality: many students are digitally active, but not digitally aware.

1. What underlying gap exists between using digital tools and understanding digital systems, and why is this gap significant?

→The most important issue in this case is the gap between *tool usage* and *system understanding*. Students today know how to use platforms efficiently—adding animations to slides, editing shared documents, or uploading projects online. However, they often do not understand what happens beyond the surface.

For example, a student may create a polished presentation but not think about copyright issues, data privacy, or how design choices influence perception. Similarly, someone might upload code on GitHub without fully understanding it, or share personal information online without considering long-term consequences.

This gap is significant because digital systems are not neutral. Every action—posting content, sharing data, or interacting online—has consequences. Without understanding these systems, students become passive users rather than responsible participants. This increases risks such as misinformation, poor decision-making, and vulnerability to cyber threats.

2. Why has the widespread availability of platforms (presentation tools, collaborative tools, and online portfolios) created an illusion of digital competence among students?

→The widespread availability of user-friendly platforms has made digital participation extremely easy. Tools like Canva, Google Slides, and collaborative workspaces are designed to simplify tasks through templates, automation, and drag-and-drop features.

Because of this, students can produce high-quality outputs without needing deep knowledge or effort. A presentation can look professional even if the content is weak. A GitHub profile can appear impressive even if the code is incomplete or copied. An online profile can showcase skills that are only superficially understood.

This creates an illusion of competence. Students start believing that because they can *produce* something, they also *understand* it. In reality, the tools are doing much of the work. Over time, this shifts the focus from learning to presentation—from actually building skills to simply appearing skilled. As seen in the case, even collaborative platforms contribute to this illusion. Group work may look complete and well-designed, but individual understanding may still be very limited.

3. *What does this case reveal about the difference between digital participation (using platforms) and digital literacy (understanding impact, responsibility, and risk)?*

→ The case clearly shows that digital participation and digital literacy are not the same thing.

- **Digital participation** means being active on platforms—creating content, sharing posts, collaborating online, and maintaining profiles.
- **Digital literacy**, on the other hand, involves understanding the impact of these actions, taking responsibility, and being aware of risks.

Arjun participates actively in digital environments, but his actions show a lack of literacy. For example:

- He builds an online presence but does not reflect on authenticity or long-term consequences.
- He collaborates online but does not fully engage in learning or accountability.
- He communicates digitally but fails to adapt his tone to professional contexts.
- He knows about cyber threats but still falls for a phishing attack due to lack of careful judgment.

These examples show that participation alone is not enough. A person can be highly active online and still make poor decisions if they lack awareness and critical thinking.

Digital literacy requires more than technical skills—it includes judgment, responsibility, and the ability to question what we see and do online. Without this, digital tools can actually increase vulnerability instead of empowering users.

SECTION B

1. *Does building a digital presence (LinkedIn, GitHub, online platforms) genuinely benefit students, or does it expose them to more risks than they realize?*

Answer:

Building a digital presence does offer benefits to students, but overall, it exposes them to more risks than they often realize. While these platforms create opportunities for visibility and networking, they also encourage superficial representation, mislead both users and viewers, and create long-term consequences that students are not fully prepared to handle.

2. *Do digital platforms truly create equal opportunities for everyone, regardless of background?*

Answer:

In theory, digital platforms seem to create equal opportunities because anyone can create a profile, upload work, and showcase their skills. A student from a small town can publish projects on GitHub or connect with professionals on LinkedIn just as easily as someone from a top university. This gives the impression that success depends only on effort and talent.

However, in practice, this idea is not entirely realistic. Visibility on these platforms often depends on factors like access to quality education, mentorship, guidance, and even awareness of how to present oneself effectively. Students who already have better resources tend to create more polished profiles, while others may struggle to compete despite having potential.

Additionally, algorithms and audience perception play a role. Profiles that look more “complete” or professionally designed are often taken more seriously, even if the actual skill level is similar. So, while opportunities are technically equal, outcomes are not. This creates a gap between the ideal and the reality.

3. *Do online platforms encourage performance over authenticity?*

Answer:

Yes, online platforms strongly encourage performance over authenticity. Students are constantly exposed to highly curated profiles where others appear skilled, productive, and successful. This creates pressure to present themselves in a similar way.

Instead of focusing on genuine learning, students often focus on how they appear to others. For example, they may list skills they have only briefly explored, upload incomplete projects, or present basic work as advanced. The goal shifts from “understanding” to “impressing.”

This performance-driven environment creates a cycle. Everyone tries to look more capable than they actually are, which raises expectations for others. As a result, authenticity becomes less valuable than visibility. Over time, students may even lose track of their actual abilities because they are more focused on maintaining an image.

4. Is misrepresentation (exaggerating skills or presenting incomplete work) ethically wrong, or is it an accepted norm?

Answer:

Misrepresentation is ethically wrong, even if it has become a common practice. Just because many students exaggerate their skills does not make it acceptable.

When a student claims expertise they do not have, it creates a false impression. This can lead to unfair advantages in opportunities like internships or projects, where others who are more honest may be overlooked. It also damages trust in digital platforms, as it becomes harder to distinguish between genuine and superficial competence.

At the same time, it is important to understand why this behavior happens. Competitive pressure pushes students to present themselves in the best possible light. They may feel that being completely honest will put them at a disadvantage. However, this does not justify the behavior—it only explains it.

In the long run, misrepresentation can backfire. If a student is unable to perform at the level they claim, it can harm their credibility and reputation. Therefore, even in competitive environments, maintaining honesty is more sustainable than following the norm of exaggeration.

5. Should students be held accountable for everything they post online, even if they lacked awareness at the time?

Answer:

Students should be held accountable to some extent, but not absolutely. Digital permanence means that what is posted online can remain visible for years, and it can influence how others perceive a person. Because of this, students must take responsibility for their digital actions.

However, it is also important to consider that many students create content without fully understanding its long-term impact. Expecting complete awareness at all times is unrealistic, especially for beginners who are still learning.

A balanced approach is necessary. Students should be encouraged to take responsibility and learn from their mistakes, but they should also be given the opportunity to grow. Instead of permanently judging someone based on early mistakes, more importance should be given to improvement over time.

Conclusion

Overall, while building a digital presence can be beneficial, it carries significant risks that students often underestimate. It creates pressure to perform rather than learn, encourages misrepresentation, and leaves a permanent record of actions that may not reflect true ability.

Therefore, digital platforms do not automatically empower students—they require careful and responsible use. Without awareness and ethical thinking, these platforms can do more harm than good.

Section C:

- 1. Are digital collaboration platforms truly enhancing learning, or are they enabling dependency and shortcuts?*

Answer:

Digital collaboration platforms do both—they enhance learning when used correctly, but they also enable dependency and shortcuts when misused.

On the positive side, these platforms make it easier to share ideas, work together in real time, and access different perspectives. They remove physical barriers and allow students to collaborate efficiently.

However, in practice, they often lead to uneven participation. Some students rely on others to complete the majority of the work, while still receiving equal credit. Copying content from online sources also becomes easier. As a result, the final output may look good, but actual understanding remains limited for many group members.

- 2. Where should the boundary be drawn between collaboration and academic dishonesty? Is it clear or ambiguous?*

Answer:

The boundary between collaboration and academic dishonesty is not always clear—it is inherently ambiguous.

Collaboration is meant to involve sharing ideas, discussing concepts, and learning together. However, it crosses into dishonesty when students submit work they do not understand, copy content without acknowledgment, or rely entirely on others' contributions.

The challenge is that digital tools do not clearly show who contributed what or how much effort each person made. Because of this, students can easily justify minimal participation as "collaboration."

Therefore, the boundary exists in principle but becomes blurred in practice, making it difficult to enforce consistently.

3. *Does reduced visibility of individual effort make ethical behavior harder to enforce?*

Answer:

Yes, reduced visibility makes ethical behavior harder to enforce.

In digital environments, contributions are often tracked in a technical sense (like edits or comments), but they do not fully reflect effort, understanding, or originality. A student can make small changes and still appear active, while another may do most of the work without recognition.

Because effort is not clearly visible, accountability decreases. When students know that their individual contribution cannot be easily evaluated, they may be more likely to take shortcuts or avoid responsibility.

4. *Construct the strongest argument that digital collaboration improves learning and should not be restricted. Do you agree?*

Answer:

The strongest argument in favor of digital collaboration is that it reflects real-world working environments. In most professional settings, teamwork, communication, and shared problem-solving are essential skills. Digital tools prepare students for this reality by allowing them to collaborate efficiently and learn from each other.

These platforms also increase access to knowledge. Students can learn from peers, share resources, and build ideas collectively. This can lead to deeper understanding compared to working alone. Restricting such tools would limit these benefits and make learning less interactive.

However, I do not fully agree with this argument. While collaboration is important, the current use of digital platforms often prioritizes completion over learning. Without proper accountability, tools can reduce individual effort .

Therefore, digital collaboration should not be restricted, but it must be used with stricter expectations of individual responsibility. Simply allowing collaboration is not enough—how it is used matters more

Section D

1. Why Cyber Crimes Continue Even with More Knowledge?

Phishing attacks work less by outsmarting tools, more by nudging emotions. Instead of facts alone, stress shapes choices - panic makes logic fade. Fear pushes people to act fast; that split second is where mistakes slip through. As firewalls grow sharper, scammers simply go around them - not through. They aim at feelings first, reasoning last. Clicks happen before thoughts do, especially when alerts flash red. Tricks win not by complexity, but by timing moments of distraction. Machines adapt slowly; humans react instantly - to pressure, to reward. A message seeming urgent rarely gives pause until after the damage shows up. Habits rule online behavior, even risky ones repeated without notice.

One person's safety shapes another's. Staying careful online means picking different passphrases every time, questioning odd messages. Yet bigger players carry heavier weight. Companies build the spaces where harm spreads - or stops - so login checks should always include extra steps, like codes or app alerts. Machines that spot strange patterns help catch scams before damage grows. If something breaks open, blame lands where protection was weak, where warnings were missing or buried. Trust fades when systems ignore clear risks.

2. Scenario Analysis Negligence Or Systemic Failure?

Most times, when a learner gets caught in a fraud, it isn't carelessness. More likely, gaps in hands-on learning play a role along with deeper flaws in structure. Schools lean heavily on abstract lessons instead of mirroring actual dangers people face. When fake websites trick someone out of school fees due to missing checks, blame lands on the system meant to guard them. That setup simply wasn't built to catch mistakes before harm happens

Right now, relying on passwords and rules only patches surface problems without fixing root causes. Information overload has made people treat alerts about safety as speed bumps slowing them down instead of shields. Biometrics or passkeys could change things - if these fit naturally into daily tasks, skipping steps might stop being so common. Only when protection feels effortless will habits finally shift

Section E Communication and Digital Etiquette

- 1. Why do students often fail to maintain professionalism in emails and online interactions despite knowing basic rules?*

Slipping up on professionalism? Blame the phone in your hand. Same screen for memes and midterm requests means lines get fuzzy fast. Enter context collapse - when casual habits invade serious spaces without warning. Without raised eyebrows or sarcastic tones to guide them, learners miss cues entirely. Talking to a professor feels like shouting into silence. The result? Tone deaf emails dressed as texts. Distance hides consequence. Familiar tools breed familiar behavior - even when it does not fit. Digital space forgets rank unless reminded. Assumptions do the rest. Polite distance fades where pings and DMs live. Expecting formality there takes work. Always. Quiet signals vanish in flat screens. What reads as lazy might just be blindness to invisible rules. Nobody models email etiquette between TikTok videos. Respect shifts shape depending on who's watching - or if anyone seems to be. Default mode leans casual until something forces pause. That moment rarely arrives. So old patterns stick. Even when they should not.

- 2. Is informal communication becoming the norm, even in professional environments? If so, is this a problem or a natural evolution?*

Out here, talking casual just makes sense - digital days move fast. Tech circles, design shops, quick messages beat long greetings every time. Yet things go sideways once meaning gets lost. Suppose a learner leans too hard into slang or shortcuts. Misreading creeps in. Maybe even offense. Teamwork suffers then. Big moments slip away.

- 3. To what extent should individuals be judged based on their digital communication style (emails, posts, comments)?*

A person's way of speaking or writing often gets mistaken for how skilled they are. Rightly or wrongly, messages packed with mistakes or shortcuts hint at carelessness. When most interactions happen online, the traces you leave behind act like a handshake before you even meet. How you communicate shapes what people think about your flexibility in work and social settings. These impressions form whether intended or not.

Section F: Reflection

1. *Before engaging with this case study, what did you think “digital literacy” meant? Has your understanding changed?*

Back then, I believed being digitally literate meant typing fast or opening files without trouble. These days, though, that idea feels shallow. What matters more is thinking carefully before sharing anything online. Using software well? That helps - but so does noticing how messages shape feelings. Even small clicks add up over time, shaping trust or confusion. Security isn't only passwords - it's also questioning why someone asks for data. Behavior leaves traces, sometimes lasting longer than intended.

2. *Is there anything in this case that surprised you, made you uncomfortable, or changed how you view your own digital habits?*

What struck me most was how little security relies on tech, how much on mind tricks. Not fun realizing firewalls won't help when I'm rushing through warnings. Excitement over a good offer? That's often the trap. Turns out, clicking fast comes easier than thinking slow. My routines online feel less like choices, more like reflexes now.

3. *Do you believe you are using digital platforms responsibly, or are there areas where you need to improve?*

Not one to break rules, I still find myself drifting without much thought behind it. Instead of acting on purpose, too many moments pass by where reactions take the lead. What ends up happening is clutter - little bits of digital trace built from impulse. These traces blur lines between work talk and casual chat. Staying aware matters, so that what I share at work doesn't echo like idle background sound.

4. *If you had to change one aspect of your digital behavior after this case study, what would it be and why?*

I bet it's the thought before tapping that link, replying to an angry message, or firing off a note - just breathing for ten counts shifts things. That brief stop lets the reason surface. How it lands matters just as much as what gets said.

I moment I wish I would take before doing a task so that I can make the right decision..